WEEK 9 · LECTURE L1 · UNITS III AND IV

Strengths Based Performance Management

Positive psychology, what a strength is, feedback intervention theory, and the critique that strengths can be overused.

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

DSEH004 · Performance Management and Employee Engagement · M.Com. PGCF 2025 · Exam preparation edition

AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain the origins of the strengths approach and three definitions of a strength.
- Explain feedback intervention theory and why feedback sometimes harms performance.
- Describe the feedforward interview as a strengths based appraisal.
- Evaluate the overuse critique and the place of weaknesses.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 1 (design performance management) and CLO 5 (create development programs).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Telling an employee clearly what is wrong with their work improves their performance.

True, false, or it depends on something you can name?

WHAT EXACTLY IS A STRENGTH?

Three definitions, three systems

Definition	What it is	What a system then does
Clifton and Harter (2003)	Talent multiplied by investment in knowledge and skill	Invest where talent is high
Peterson and Seligman (2004)	24 character strengths under six virtues	Use signature strengths daily
Linley (2008)	A capacity that is authentic and energizing to use	Ask what energizes, not only what scores high

EXAM LENS

Positive psychology (Seligman and Csikszentmihalyi, 2000) proposed studying what makes people flourish, not only what goes wrong.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KLUGER AND DENISI (1996)

Feedback intervention theory

THE CORE IDEA

Feedback improves performance on average, but in over a third of cases it reduced performance.

HOW IT WORKS

Feedback moves attention. Toward the task, performance rises; toward the self, it falls as effort goes to protecting the self.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Much of the evidence comes from laboratory tasks; workplace feedback is more complex.

IN PRACTICE

A public ranking or a weakness label pulls attention to the self, so performance may fall.

EXAM LENS

Use it to explain why annual appraisal can backfire. Cite the 607 effect sizes and the harmful third.

A DESIGN BUILT ON THAT THEORY · KLUGER AND NIR (2010)

The feedforward interview

STORY OF SUCCESS

The employee describes a time at work when they were at their best

›

CONDITIONS

Together, name what made it possible: actions, manager, setting

›

FEEDFORWARD

How close is current work to those conditions?

›

GOALS FROM THE GAP

Set goals from that distance, so attention stays on the task

Bouskila-Yam and Kluger (2011) built a strength based appraisal and goal setting process on this idea.

THEORY IN DEPTH · VAN WOERKOM AND MEYERS (2015)

Does a strengths climate help?

THE CORE IDEA

A climate that supports the use of strengths relates to positive affect and job performance.

HOW IT WORKS

Employees who feel their organization supports strengths use report more positive affect, which links to performance.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Self reported, and much wider strengths evidence comes from the vendors who sell the assessments.

IN PRACTICE

A team lead asks each person to spend part of the week on work that uses their strongest skill.

EXAM LENS

Ask of any strengths claim: who measured it, against what comparison, and was the outcome performance or feeling good?

THE CRITIQUE

Strengths can be overused

GRANT AND SCHWARTZ (2011)

Many traits follow an inverted U: beyond a point, more of a strength harms performance.

KAISER AND OVERFIELD (2011)

Leaders rated highly on a strength were often rated as overdoing it.

AGUINIS, GOTTFREDSON AND JOO (2012)

Weaknesses that block the job must still be addressed: strengths first is a sequence.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

A long serving quality specialist, four theories

Theory	What it sees	Design it implies
Deficit model	Gaps against a manager competency list	Training for leadership readiness
Strengths (Clifton)	Deep talent in precision and judgment	Invest further in the specialist domain
Feedback intervention	Threats to standing cost effort	Task focused feedback; no ranking talk
Inverted U	Rigor that can tip into resistance	Name the overuse risk with the strength

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Focusing on weaknesses is a waste of time." Critically evaluate the strengths based approach. **20 marks**

A strong answer: defines strengths; uses Kluger and DeNisi and Kluger and Nir; presents the overuse critique and Aguinis et al.; concludes with a sequence.

Design a strengths based appraisal for an Indian firm and identify its risks. **20 marks**

A strong answer: uses the feedforward interview; links goals to the gap; addresses manager skill, culture and overuse.

Why can feedback reduce performance? **10 marks**

A strong answer: explains the shift of attention to the self; cites the meta analysis; one example.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. Feedback reduced performance in over a third of cases
2. Keep attention on the task, not the self
3. Strengths first is a sequence, not an amnesty for weaknesses

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Buckingham, M., & Clifton, D. O. (2001). *Now, discover your strengths*. Free Press. Chapter 1.

Cappelli, P. (2008). *Talent on demand: Managing talent in an age of uncertainty*. Harvard Business Press. Chapter on internal mobility.

Hewlett, S. A. (2013). *Forget a mentor, find a sponsor: The new way to fast track your career*. Harvard Business Review Press. Chapter 1.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 9 set readings. Buckingham and Clifton (2001) is the core reading for this lecture.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture (1 of 4)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Aguinis, H., Gottfredson, R. K., & Joo, H. (2012). Delivering effective performance feedback: The strengths based approach. *Business Horizons, 55*(2), 105–111. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.bushor.2011.10.004

Bouskila-Yam, O., & Kluger, A. N. (2011). Strength based performance appraisal and goal setting. *Human Resource Management Review, 21*(2), 137–147. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hrmr.2010.09.001

Clifton, D. O., & Harter, J. K. (2003). Investing in strengths. In K. S. Cameron, J. E. Dutton, & R. E. Quinn (Eds.), *Positive organizational scholarship* (pp. 111–121). Berrett Koehler.

Sources for this lecture (2 of 4)

Grant, A. M., & Schwartz, B. (2011). Too much of a good thing: The challenge and opportunity of the inverted U. *Perspectives on Psychological Science, 6*(1), 61–76. https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691610393523

Kaiser, R. B., & Overfield, D. V. (2011). Strengths, strengths overused, and lopsided leadership. *Consulting Psychology Journal: Practice and Research, 63*(2), 89–109. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0024470

Kluger, A. N., & DeNisi, A. (1996). The effects of feedback interventions on performance: A historical review, a meta analysis, and a preliminary feedback intervention theory. *Psychological Bulletin, 119*(2), 254–284. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.2.254

Sources for this lecture (3 of 4)

Kluger, A. N., & Nir, D. (2010). The feedforward interview. *Human Resource Management Review, 20*(3), 235–246. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hrmr.2009.08.002

Linley, A. (2008). *Average to A+: Realising strengths in yourself and others*. CAPP Press.

Peterson, C., & Seligman, M. E. P. (2004). *Character strengths and virtues: A handbook and classification*. Oxford University Press.

Seligman, M. E. P., & Csikszentmihalyi, M. (2000). Positive psychology: An introduction. *American Psychologist, 55*(1), 5–14. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066x.55.1.5

Sources for this lecture (4 of 4)

van Woerkom, M., & Meyers, M. C. (2015). My strengths count! Effects of a strengths based psychological climate on positive affect and job performance. *Human Resource Management, 54*(1), 81–103. https://doi.org/10.1002/hrm.21623